of walking on the burning embers of fire, or 'Petals of Fire', practised in some areas near Coimbatore as a mark of faith. "This is what happens to Saroja. She has to endure an ordeal by fire. But does that include the meaning that you have given in your English title, 'Pyre'? Does that reflect the poetic title 'Pookuzhi'?" I ask Murugan.

"It is not possible to bring certain elements in translation. We have something called 'Mangala vazhakku' in Tamil. To replace inauspicious terms with auspicious terms. It's part of Tamil culture and language. It is difficult to bring it in translation. A lot of thought went into this before finalising the title 'Pyre'. Some elements will be lost in translation, some elements in translation will make it rich."

Finally, I question whether it's the portrayals of female sexuality in all its hidden manifestations that engages his attention as a writer rather than, say, the politics of class and caste? "We could perhaps speak politics directly in political novels. My novels are not such," says Murugan, "but politics remains an intrinsic aspect of my work. I do not believe that a social change or a political change is possible through writing. I am not familiar with the theories of sexual politics. Fundamentally, my writings are classified as realism. Is there no space for fiction or extremes in reality? Life is central to my writing." ■

Geeta Doctor

BOOKS

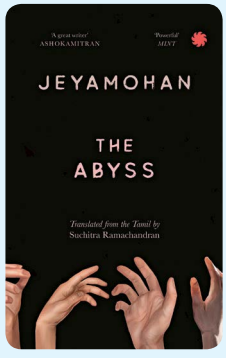
Found in Translation

There has been a slew of translations of Tamil books recently, opening them up to a wider audience

AN ORDER FROM THE SKY AND OTHER STORIES

by Imayam (translated by Vasantha Surya)
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA | ₹**399; 356** pages

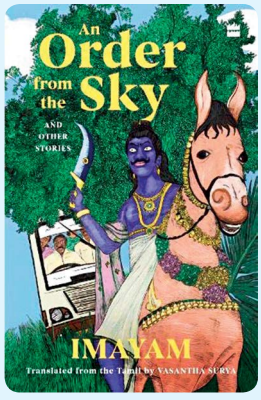
Imayam is the pen-name of V. Annamalai, one of the leading contemporary Tamil writers. He won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2020 for *Selladha Panam*. In this collection of stories, set mostly in villages and small towns across Tamil Nadu, ordinary people are forced to confront their innermost fears and desires, the things they grudgingly do every day to get by. Imayam captures the texture of lived reality better than most.



THE ABYSS

by Jeyamohan (translated by Suchitra Ramachandran)
JUGGERNAUT BOOKS
₹**699; 352** pages

Jeyamohan is a veteran Tamil writer with over 20 books of fiction and co-writing credits on several hit movies, including Mani Ratnam's recent *Ponniyin Selvan II*. *The Abyss* was the basis for Bala's 2009 film *Naan Kadavul*, for which Jeyamohan had written the dialogues. The narrative follows an 'aghori' who stands up against the tyranny of a human trafficking gang specialising in deformed children (who are then forced to beg). A dark, powerfully told story where just about every character has shades of grey.

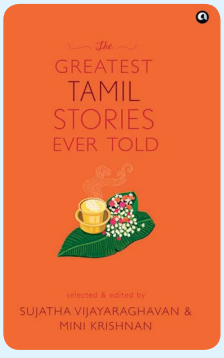




BREAKING FREE
A Novel

by Vaasanthi (translated by N. Kalyan Raman)
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹**399; 352** pages

Vaasanthi's novel follows its two heroines through the course of their lives. Kasturi is born into a devadasi clan and earmarked to become a temple dancer upon reaching puberty, while Lakshmi escapes her roots to become a doctor and a reformer who seeks to end the devadasi system. Their lives collide again and again through the novel until we come to the book's stunning third act. A thought-provoking meditation on art, freedom, patriarchy and conformity.



THE GREATEST TAMIL STORIES EVER TOLD

Edited by Sujatha Vijayaraghavan and Mini Krishnan
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹**799; 312** pages

A collector's item for aficionados of Tamil literature, this anthology features the best-known Tamil writers of the last 100 years and more. From pioneers like Subramania Bharati and 'Kalki' Krishnamurthy to contemporary maestros like Perumal Murugan, Ambai and Poomani, this book brings together the best of Tamil writing across eras. As Vasantha Surya notes in the foreword, most of these writers share "a literary aesthetic premised on a no-holds-barred ethic of doubt and questioning".

by Aditya Mani Jha